Research Statement

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October 9, 2026

I am a macroeconomist who studies how people make economic decisions in changing macroeconomic environments beyond their control and how those decisions, in turn, affect broad macroeconomic outcomes. I have been particularly interested in young adults, who are more vulnerable to exogenous macroeconomic shocks and more resource-constrained than older generations. First of all, my research so far has focused on macro-labor questions, such as how changes in working arrangements toward a hybrid between work-on-site (WOS) and work-from-home (WFH) affect workers' productivity and economic growth. I also studied how family structure during adolescence relates to employment instability in the post-school period among young adults. Going forward, I am extending my research interest to macro-finance, such as how younger generations make financial decisions in an economy where accumulating wealth and achieving financial goals have become increasingly challenging. Across these projects, I use macroeconomic structural models with empirical evidence to understand the economy, identify the mechanisms behind it, and evaluate how changes in economic environment or policy interventions may alter the individual and aggregate outcomes.

1 Family Structure and Employment Instability

My job market paper, *Family Structure and Youth Employment Instability: Evidence on Job Quality and Match Stability*, examines whether family structure during adolescence relates to employment instability in young adulthood and, if so, in which labor market transitions the family-structure gap emerges. My interests in this question originates from my personal background. My father grew up in a single-mother household and entered into labor market right after high school, and he used to tell me about forgone educational opportunities because he had to care for his single mother and siblings, and earn money. This made me wonder how family backgrounds might shape young adults' labor market opportunities. Existing literature on family structure has largely focused on economic outcomes such as educational attainment, wages, life-time earnings, and permanent income. My paper instead focuses on labor market dynamics after young adults leave school, asking where and how in the sequence of employment and unemployment transitions the family-structure margin arises.

Using detailed weekly employment histories from the National Longitudinal Survey of Youth 1997 (NLSY97), I find that young adults from single-parent households experience higher unemployment after leaving school, and this gap is primarily driven by higher employment-to-unemployment (EU) transitions rather than systematically slower job finding rates. This pattern remains statistically significant even after conditioning on measures of human capital and financial resources, which indicates that the association between family structure and employment instability is not simply a reflection of observable covariates. I also find that the characteristics of jobs accepted by workers from single-parent households differ in both wage quality and match durability. I analyze these empirical evidence through an extended Baydur and Mukoyama (2020) job-ladder model in which the family-structure wedge parameter tilts the distribution of accessible job opportunities for workers from single-parent households.

My paper contributes to bringing a dynamic perspective to the study of intergenerational inequality by shifting attention from differences in stock variables to labor market transition dynamics. It provides a detailed picture of family-structure gaps behind wage inequality and differences in permanent income, and show how family-structure margins propagate through labor market transitions. As a result, it gives a better understanding of the reality workers from single-parent households face in the labor market, and it calls for relevant policy interventions.

2 Working Arrangements and Productivity Growth

A second strand of my research examines how changes in working arrangements affect workers' productivity and aggregate economic growth. My paper, *Work-From-Home, Worker Interactions, and Economic Growth*, also began with another personal experience that shaped my own early career. I started my Ph.D. in August 2020. It was right in the middle of the COVID-19 pandemic. As an international student newly arrived in the United States, I spend much of the beginning of the program working remotely. This experience made me think about something difficult to observe directly: how much do young or less-skilled workers learn simply by being around more skillful workers?

In this paper, I study the effects of remote and hybrid working arrangements when worker interactions are an important channel for learning and improving productivity. I use Lucas Jr and Moll (2014) model, in which workers differ in productivity and can improve through interactions with more skillful workers. A shift toward remote work affects not only where workers work today, but also whom they encounter, from whom they learn, and how the productivity distribution evolves over time. I also compare WFH days among week days in a decentralized economy with the optimal outcome in the social planner's problem.

This project reflects an interesting aspect of macroeconomics: individually optimized choices are not always the same as the socially optimal outcomes. For instance, the private value of

flexibility from remote work need not necessarily incorporate all of the learning and teaching opportunities generated through face-to-face interactions. Understanding these differences between individual incentives and aggregate outcomes is one reason I find structure macroeconomics models useful for determining which policy tools can achieve socially optimal outcomes.

In its current version, the paper compares the individually optimized equilibrium and the socially optimal outcome at the aggregate level. The model predicts 100% remote work for the most skillful workers in the decentralized economy, but the social planner's outcome suggests that more skillful workers work on-site to internalize the externality of being on-site to teach less skillful workers through face-to-face interactions. A natural next step is to introduce heterogeneity across industries to compute optimal WFH days by industry once richer industry-level data on workplace interactions become available.

3 Young Adults and Financial Choices

My recent research interest extends to the financial decisions of young generations. I am particularly interested in risk-taking behavior among young investors regarding investments in lottery-like assets and cryptocurrency. These behaviors are obviously distinct from those of older generations, as supported by several empirical studies. Rather than assuming younger generations are simply more risk-loving or irrational, I want to ask what economic environment drives their risk-taking decisions within the mainstream macroeconomics framework.

Recent literature suggests the housing market as one channel behind young adults' risk-taking behavior. When financial goals become more difficult to attain, investors are more likely to take risks to cross the certain threshold. Housing policy that aims to reduce house prices makes housing consumption more attainable, which in turn boosts young adults' risk-taking behavior, resulting in housing demand and offsetting the effectiveness of housing policy. Implementing housing policy without accounting for this mechanism could be misleading. So my paper proposes developing a quantitative model to evaluate relevant policy while reflecting young investors' risk-taking behavior.

This project expands my research rather than departing from my previous work. My research interest began with younger generations and the labor market, but I do not want to confine myself to macro-labor. No matter where I work or what I do, the research question that stays at the center of my mind will be: how people make economic decisions in changing macroeconomic environments beyond their control, and how those decisions, in turn, affect broad macroeconomic outcomes.

4 Final Remark

I do not see describing economic reality, identifying mechanism, and evaluating policy as competing research goals. Good research often combines them. It starts by illustrating what kind of world we live in, unravels hidden mechanisms, and calls for proper policy intervention. I hope to be a macroeconomist who can achieve those research goals and satisfy the research agenda the upcoming world calls for.

References

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